—without expecting quid pro quo.[145] Dixit's June 1997 statement that India should have a 'flexible approach towards the Taliban' supported this stand.[146] However, regardless of Gujral and Dixit's advocacy, India took sides. The R&AW provided active support to Rabbani and Massoud, as alleged by Muttawakil in October 1996 and proven in retrospect. The fact was that India's activities in Afghanistan (particularly military support to Rabbani's forces) did not have political clearance (just yet). Politically, India had nothing to do with the internal situation of Afghanistan. Therefore, while the conciliatory advocacy dominated policy output between 1992 and 1996 and later gained some momentum in light of the Taliban's territorial gains in North Afghanistan in 1997, it remained unsuccessful in shaping the practical course of actions after the fall of Kabul.

Rise of the partisans

Running parallel to the conciliators' advocacy were proponents of containment of the Taliban. Here termed partisans, these officials advocated containing the Taliban by bolstering anti-Taliban elements in Afghanistan. To be clear, the conciliators and the partisans were in agreement over facts such as Pakistan's support to the Taliban. With the same resource and information available to advocates of both these coalitions, the difference lay in approach. There were three key aspects to the partisans' belief system. Firstly, that the Taliban was a 'Pakistan-raised, Pakistan-trained and equipped, new Islamist fundamentalist force' in Afghanistan.[147] Secondly, that the Taliban would advance Pakistan's strategic interests instead of uniting Afghanistan. Thirdly, not only should the Taliban not be recognised but also active counter-measures should be taken to stop its ascent. There was consensus in India's political circles that the Taliban was a 'creation' of the ISI.[148] K. Subrahmanyam, a top Indian strategist, reported on the Taliban's links with Pakistan and Saudi Arabia in December 1994, and noted the West's (primarily the US) 'tacit' support to the student movement.[149] Indeed, foreign secretary Srinivasan gave multiple warnings to Frank Wisner, the then US ambassador to India, but received no response (and viewed that as US complicity in the rise of the Taliban).[150]